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JEWISH RHETORICAL USES OF INDIANS IN AN ERA OF NATIVIST ANXIETIES

In establishing themselves economically as commercially valuable suppliers and builders in America's West, Jews enjoyed significant upward mobility in the last decades of the nineteenth century. Part of American Jews' civic and fiscal arrival in the West owed itself to the economic opportunities generated by Jewish encounters with Native Americans. Western Jews positioned themselves as commercial traders of foodstuffs, dry goods, and inexpensive merchandise between whites and Native Americans. They served as economic middlemen between Native producers of curios and those non-Indian consumers of "Indianness" too.¹ Through their economic, social, and imagined encounters with Native Americans, Jews advanced their twin goals in the West in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries—namely, economic mobility and cultural integration. But the Jewish position vis-à-vis Native people in the United States was not entirely middling. Jews were not "between" settlers and Indigenous People; they were clearly part of the settler colonial population. Jews acted as colonial agents and frequently relished the privileges of being figured as white, enjoying its benefits in the frontier West. They suffered virtually none of the barriers to enfranchisement or social or economic mobility of Indians, Blacks, Asians, or Mexicans. Jews proudly identified as harbingers of civilization and active agents in the advancement of American national interests through Indian pacification and the expansion of settlement and capitalism. The crude fact is that Jews stood on the "winning" side of the frontier process that had ultimately and profoundly deleterious effects on Native American life.

In the early years of the twentieth century, with the Indian Wars largely over, the West "won," the frontier considered by most whites closed, and the explosion of new immigrant populations, Americans debated just what, exactly, constituted the heart of American identity. They wove a thorny knot of ideas about

race, nation, and religion, into which Jews and Indians—alongside many other American “minority” groups—were tied. New to the ongoing discussion about corporate group identity in the early twentieth century was a befuddled mix of social, scientific, polity oriented, popular, and high cultural discourses concentrated around the notion of “race.” Those who offered a vision to “protect” the white, Christian, “original” inhabitants of the United States from new off-white and non-Protestant immigrants or other racial outsiders were known as nativists; their anti-immigrant and often anti-Indian movement was generally referred to as nativism.²

Who were the Jews and who were Indians in these discussions? What was a race? Were Jews or Indians examples of a “pure race”? Was being a “mixed race” a justification for exclusion or evidence of assimilability and virtue? How were Jewish and Indian “racial” identities linked to or detached from those other categories that were also used to define peoplehood—namely, nation, and religion? Where were Jews and Indians respectively located in the social imagination? How did Jews intervene in this rhetoric, and how did they use Indians in those interventions?

American nativist sentiment in the early decades of the twentieth century targeted Jews and Native Americans and forced both groups to develop strategies of resistance. Anti-Semitism and anti-Indian sentiment paralleled one another and spurred Jewish and Indian fiction writers and journalists to contest ideas about them that were underpinned by the same ideological “structure of domination.”³ This chapter describes where and how Jews and Native Americans were figured in American nativist discourse. It shows that Jews responded to nativism and that part of this response involved evoking rhetorical uses of Indians in support of their aims. American Jews deployed ideas about American Indians in their engagements with, responses to, and creation of racial discourse. In defending themselves against an array of defamations, and in waging a discursive and ultimately failed war with the forces that aimed to halt new Jewish immigration from eastern Europe to the United States, American Jews made rhetorical uses of Indians that were far from consistent. On the one hand, they recapitulated hierarchical visions of racial belonging that put Native Americans beneath Jews, thereby agreeing to the terms of nativist sentiment and arguing, as selective nativists themselves, for their own rightful place in the emerging landscape of belonging. On the other hand, American Jews also inveighed against race thinking altogether and developed a new antirace ideology that they hoped would end acrimony directed at Jews, Native Americans, and all other American minorities.

American Jews pursued both these strategies despite the fact that the two were at odds with one another. While one strategy aimed to leverage exclusionist understandings of corporate difference to elevate Jewish standing to those with the most privilege, the other tried to level the playing field, placing Jews as

a minority among other minorities. The contradiction seemed not to have mattered. American Jews were poised between champions of the broader colonial settler population in the late nineteenth-century West (discussed in chapters 1, 2, and 3) and the liberal, progressive attitude many Jews would take up by the middle of the twentieth century (discussed in chapters 5 and 6). Jewish efforts to intervene against anti-immigration policy in particular—the most potent manifestation of early twentieth-century American nativism as far as Jews were concerned—led to a newfound antirace impulse among a portion of American Jews, an essential part of which inspired many midcentury Jews to social justice and civil and human rights work for and with Native Americans.

JEWS AND INDIANS IN THE RISE OF AMERICAN RACIAL THINKING

Though race thinking had a century-long history by the turn of the twentieth century, its scope and popularity skyrocketed after 1900. Race science and eugenics impacted virtually all fields of social life, from churches to the military, from sports and entertainment to higher education, and in health, banking, food, vice, sex, marriage, and childhood. Many of the most influential race science operatives, executives, and chief advocates received funding from the same sources. They were affiliated with a set of interconnected bodies founded in the first two decades of the twentieth century, including the Immigration Restriction League, the American Breeders Association, the Race Betterment Foundation, the International Federation of Eugenics Organizations, the Galton Society, the American Eugenics Society, the Pioneer Fund, and its main driving force, Wickliffe Preston Draper.⁴ Mainstream social scientists and other civic activists funded popular dissemination of books, pamphlets, and journals like *Western Destiny*, *Mankind Quarterly*, and the *Liberty Lobby*. Racial theory dealt not just with the scientific explorations about group identity but also with rights: who could or should be educated, enjoy citizenship and the franchise, and even have children. For race thinkers, race provided the key to social progress, public education, social harmony, national welfare, and the future of humanity.⁵

American nativists linked together the fear that true Americans might, for the first time in its history, run out of usable land with the longstanding conviction that Indians would inevitably disappear from modernity or be fully assimilated to white ways. This toxic blend of anxiety and misunderstanding shifted many American discussions about race, land, and citizenship away from Native Americans and toward Blacks and, to a growing extent, the ethnic urban immigrant poor. The early decades of the twentieth century saw a hardening of race thinking into two categories—Black and white—and a growing disquiet about the possibilities of crossing the divide. Yet in virtually all the hierarchies of race that eugenicists, racial thinkers, social commentators, and scholars created, Indians were ranked at or near the bottom. Those peoples who remained stubbornly neither “white” nor “black” were frequently slated into one of the two

categories; Indians became problematically Black, while Jews became problematically white. While Jews, unlike Indians, Mexicans, and Asians, for the most part benefited from this hardening of peoplehood into a racial binary, the questions that were brought to bear on one minority were also brought to bear on the others: were these “others” assimilable? Could they make good citizens? What would mixing with them do to the nation’s body politic, its religious character, or the mental and moral health of its future generations? Their existence and persistence raised challenges and fears about the singularity and superiority of the white race.⁶

By the turn of the twentieth century, Jews were receiving considerable attention and worry in nativist racial schemas. As historian Eric Goldstein has shown, by the 1890s, Jewish racial stereotypes had become popular on the vaudeville stage; in humor magazines, weekly magazines, and journals; and social commentaries.⁷ Their putative nervousness, intellectuality, and lack of physical development—all Indian opposites—exemplified effects of life confined to cities, a metropolis, alienated from nature, where American identity was ideally forged (frontier or farm).⁸ As Jewish immigration from eastern Europe swelled to unprecedented numbers, Jews became objects in popular media representations like plays, jokes, political cartoons, and songs as well as in social and political discourse preoccupied with American ideals, its future character, and the nature of Americanism. Jews served as a convenient symbol for a host of social problems and issues that were of mounting concern, linked as they were in the popular mind to commerce, the city, and modernity itself.

The case was the reverse for American Indians. Before the twentieth century, Indians took up a great deal of space in the social imaginary of corporate difference, while in the twentieth they began to recede from the nation’s discussion. Blacks and immigrants, by contrast, took stage at the center of the drama of American belonging. With a few noteworthy exceptions, Indians appeared surprisingly few times, and often merely in passing, from the canonical texts of race scientists and eugenics writers. Elided from the discourse on race, according to a logic that assumed social evolution and accorded tremendous virtue in longevity, the idea of Indian disappearance became central to notions of race longevity and crucial to the debate about assimilability of various nonwhite races.

Native Americans invariably ranked at or close to the bottom of the racial hierarchies that American scholars, commentators, and nativists imagined, while Jews were classed more ambiguously, though in all cases higher than Indians. American assessments about race occasionally discussed both Jews and Native Americans in the same text. Newspapers, journals, lawyers, and activists, for example, repeatedly compared the trial of Spotted Hawk and Little Whirlwind, wrongly accused for the murder of a white herder in Miles City, Montana, in the late 1890s to the Dreyfus Affair.⁹ The Philadelphia physician Samuel George Morton, whose book *Crania Americana*, supplied data on the cranial capacities of some eight hundred skulls, found Indians “averse to cultivation,”

"altogether repulsive . . . slow & stupid," with vacant expressions on their faces.¹⁰ An esteemed scientists and protoethnographer in his day, Morton viewed the differences between humans as a matter of species difference (rather than of variety among humans).¹¹ He described the Delaware Tribe with reference to Jews, concluding that "their bodies were strong, but of a strength rather fitted to endure hardship than to sustain much bodily labor; their features were regular; their countenances sometimes fierce, in common rather resembling a Jew than a Christian."¹² Morton's conclusions about "Hebrews" echoed qualities he had ascribed to Indians: "[The Hebrew's] zealous attachment to their religion, and their patient endurance of adversity," he wrote, "are among the most striking traits of their character."¹³ For Morton, Jews and Indians were similar in their zeal, their attachment to old religion, their being stiff-necked and past-oriented people. Jews, however, succeeded at survival, whereas Indians, he assumed, were failing.

Other scholars suggested parallels between the Jewish and the Indian "character." Writers throughout the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries frequently fashioned both Jews and Indians as ancient peoples. In some writers' hands, the ancient Jewish past was intimately interwoven into the Jews' character, culture, or even blood, while in others' readings, modernity had severed the Jews' ancient moral and religious underpinning. Jews were imagined as simultaneously the most ancient of peoples and the most modern, as a people able to preserve their ancient ways and employ them as a moral guide as they faced the complexities of modernity.¹⁴ According to this line of thinking, Jews might serve as a model of how Americans might survive the degradation of the modern world with their religious and value systems intact, unlike Indians, who could not serve as any useful model, given their inevitable disappearance. American Indians' "ancientness," by contrast, apparently inured them to the benefits of modernity and made them the subjects of Christian missionary and government efforts, which had ultimately failed to domesticate or assimilate Indians.¹⁵

Jews and Native Americans symbolized many different things to the non-Jews and non-Indians who wrote about them after the turn of the century. Jews symbolized the capitalist ethos, for which they were alternately praised or condemned, while Indians, by contrast, were perennially accused of dismal and woefully inadequate business acumen, as the symbolic figure for whom modernity—its capitalism and its urbanism—would inevitably leave behind. The matter of the "pure" or "mixed" status of so-called racial groups in America at times placed Jews and Indians into relation with one another. The place of Jews in racialist thinking was sometimes honored and celebrated for Jews' apparent purity of race, often contrasted with Indians, the quintessentially "mongrelized," as one leading historian, journalist, eugenicist, political theorist, anti-immigration advocate, and champion of scientific racism, Theodore Lothrop Stoddard, put it.¹⁶ Another nativist, Alfred Schultz, claimed to account for the rises and falls of the ancient races on earth and the implications of these patterns on American immigration policy in his book *Race or Mongrel?* Schultz referenced "Indians"

from dozens of countries, each time as “interbred,” “mongrelized,” “crossed,” and “compounded.” Schultz argued, by contrast, that “the Jews’ knowledge of the physiological law that promiscuous crossing degrades, deteriorates, mongrelizes the participants, enabled them to develop from a small Eastern tribe into one of the great nations of the earth. . . . The Jews have brought forth poets, writers, artists, scientists, financiers, and philanthropists.”¹⁷ Indians ceased to be a pure race and, in so far as they blended with others, deteriorated their purity. Jews succeeded, he claimed,

because . . . they belong to a great race, and they kept and do keep that race pure. The greatest mongrelizing machine of antiquity, the empire called the Roman did not succeed in mongrelizing them. America will not be able to destroy them. The Jews have overcome well-nigh insurmountable obstacles; they are succeeding everywhere, because they have been and do remain true to themselves, that is, true to their race instincts. They demonstrate to the world that the blood that courses in the veins of the individual is more sacred than gold, silver, territory flag, and country. . . . Race purity is the secret of the success of the Jews.¹⁸

For Schultz, the inevitable future success of the Jews in America rested on Jews’ supposed racial purity, while by contrast, Indians’ inevitable decline rested on Indians’ inability to remain racially pure. Jews and Indians, in his schema, were object lessons for white America, case studies that ought to inspire intense racial boundary enforcement.

In some popular, scholarly, and policy-oriented projections that grappled with ideas of racial purity or with totems of modernity, Jews and Indians were presented as opposite “types.” But in other discussions, writers cut Jews and Indians from precisely the same cloth. The essential preoccupation that would bring any commentator to consider both Jews and Indians concerned the extent to which either was assimilable. **Nonwhite groups were routinely compared and pitted against one another as better or worse candidates for successful assimilation.** Nathaniel Shaler’s 1904 work, *The Neighbor*, argued that both Jews and Indians could be assimilated into white America, though the differences and comparisons between them were instructive. Shaler, the dean of Harvard’s Lawrence Scientific School, observed that Jews, “like blacks and Indians,” inspired repugnance on account of their racial features. He nonetheless argued that Jews were “nearer to ourselves than the people of any other stock” and that the “inter-tribal repugnance” experienced with them “should certainly be much less than that which we experience in meeting Africans or American Indians.”¹⁹

Shaler suggested that both peoples held the promise of being full humans, on par in some ways and perhaps even superior to whites in others. While “people of [American Indian] stock are, as regards their general intelligence, little, if at all, below the average of Europeans,” he claimed, “their physical development is

probably rather above the plane of the so-called Aryan folk.”²⁰ Indians’ innate qualities, however, had limitations that rendered them easily subjected to external rule. For Shaler, Indians lacked “energetic power,” and therefore they suffered as incompetent laborers. “This lack of capacity to apply energy in a continuous manner,” he wrote, “appears to be due to some peculiarity of the nervous system. . . . The fate of the Indian in contact with the peoples of northern Europe appears to have been in large measure determined by his inability to labor.”²¹ Similarly, Shaler concluded that the Jews, despite their good quality “stock” of innate qualities, were out of step with the kind of labor that modernity required of races to succeed. “The Semite is, on the whole, the ablest type of man the world has known,” he wrote, “but a type which is somewhat archaic for the reason that its powers are not those most intimately related to the life of the genus in its present stage or in its foreseeable future.”²² As a racial type, Shaler’s Jews were of the highest order but stuck in the past and held back by tradition, which curtailed Jews’ ability to assimilate or progress.

Amid all his traffic in racial stereotyping, Shaler concluded his best-selling book with a surprisingly liberal plea for his white readers to transcend these misconstrued stereotypes. Arguing against the stereotypes that shape “our” Aryan impressions of others, he beseeched his readers to consider how intensely social categories and “habits of mind” misshape real people and therefore distort and curb their abilities to live decent American lives. Reflecting on his own unchecked assumptions as a rhetorical device, as a way of modeling his own thinking for his readers, he wrote that “the dominating power of the categorizing habit that the Indian . . . appears to me as he does to the frontiersman as that kind of man who is good when he is dead. So it is in all our contacts with our fellow-men; we have inherited from the lower life, that of the brutes and brutal man, a habit which leads to a classification of our kind, embodying hatreds as animal in their nature as those which exist between dogs and foxes—such categories as are labeled ‘Vile Jew’ and the like.”²³ Shaler protested against all these “classification” prejudices and aimed his readers at overcoming them, concluding that

whoever will essay this task [of reexamining biases] will be surprised to find how differently the fellow-man appears in the new light; how changed indeed is the whole world with the old scales fallen from our eyes. There are no more common people, “dogs of Jews,” or “Indians good when they are dead,” but each stands before us in the dignity of his manhood as a presentation of the hundred million years of life of this world summed in that marvelous personality of man. Whoever sees this in his fellow has seen into the promised land; he has in a true sense gained religion.²⁴

Shaler stood out as one who argued on behalf of Indian and Jewish assimilability, going so far as to suggest that those Americans who could recognize the humanity in these and other outsiders would receive divine favor. Others,

however, suggested that Jews but not Indians, or neither Jews nor Indians, could assimilate on account of their supposed racial status. The most popular anti-Jewish integration stance of the early twentieth century emphasized the Jews' supposed fixed racial nature, making any change nary impossible, a view most bluntly articulated by Madison Grant. Unlike Shaler, Grant argued that no amount of racial intermixing would change the core racial makeup of groups that he perceived as nonwhite like Jews or Native Americans. "A cross between a white man and an Indian is an Indian, white man and a Hindu is a Hindu, white and negro is a negro and the cross between any of the three European races and a Jew is a Jew," he wrote in his highly influential book, *The Passing of the Great Race*, in 1913. "Whether we like to admit it or not, the result of the mixture of two races in the long run, gives us a race reverting to the most ancient, generalized and lower type," he concluded, leading to his judgment of intermarriage as a "social and racial crime."²⁵ Grant loathed the Jews' supposed "dwarf stature, peculiar mentality, and ruthless concentration of self-interest," which, he argued, "are being engrafted upon the stock of the nation."²⁶ In a letter he wrote to the House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization more than a decade later, Grant emphasized the principle argument of immigration restrictionism and encouraged the committee to establish quotas from the nations that "furnish very undesirable immigrants [like . . .] the Mexicans who come into the United States [who are] overwhelmingly of Indian blood."²⁷ Grant was far from alone in his conviction that Jews were racially fixed and, as such, could neither assimilate nor become naturalized Americans, nor that Indians were racially mixed and therefore unable to assimilate. Dozens of commentators were preoccupied with questions about whether the apparent fixedness of the Jewish, Indian, Black, and Chinese races rendered them incapable of assimilation.

If the degree to which Jews and Indians could be assimilated, their capacities for labor, or the extent to which they were essentially ancient people (for better or for worse) were three versions of the same question about Jews' and Indians' respective differences from white America, commentators, policy makers, and scholars also analyzed other dimensions of their differences. Jews and Indians were likewise assessed and compared in relation to their agrarian capacities, their tendencies to segregate, their location on imagined evolutionary ladders of human civilization and with respect to the likelihood of their respective collective disappearance. Anti-Jewish and anti-Indian sentiment that stressed how both groups were fundamentally incompatible with agrarian life cast Jews as quintessential urbanites, unable to handle farm life, and Indians as unable to learn to farm or sustain a living from it. William Z. Ripley, an economist who had written a 624-page tome *The Races of Europe* in 1899, delivered a lecture at MIT in 1908 called "The Migration of Races," which described the "unfavorable influence of city life" and the "physically degenerate" impact it made on the Jew, who congregated in commercial centers with his "inherent dislike of labor and physical exercise."²⁸ With "narrow chests," "defective stature," and "deficient

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(S. 1913)

lung capacity," he claimed, Jews remained "one of the most stunted peoples in Europe."²⁹ Indians, by contrast, were simply incapable of achieving agrarian success.

A distinct strain of exclusionary animus suggested that Jews and Indians were races who self-segregated and were thereby incompatible with others on the land, the inevitable instigators of violent group conflict. "Groups that cannot mix segregate," wrote William Christie Macleod, "thus we get the Jewish Ghetto, the negro quarters in American cities, and reservations of the Indians."³⁰

Scholars also observed/imagined symmetries between Jewish and Indian religious life—their rites, lore, or cosmology—which suggested that ancient Jews and more-or-less contemporary Indians were located on the same evolutionary rung.³¹ In one remarkable series of pages in a volume on biblical anthropology from 1929, H. J. D. Astley switched between Israelite and Indian rites and categories without pause, making it, on occasion, difficult to tell whose rites he was discussing at a given point (perhaps by design).³² He concluded, "There is no race of men that has not passed through a period of totemism in the course of its upward progress from savagery through barbarism to civilization: it was certainly the case among the Semites, of whom the Hebrews were a younger and comparatively modern branch; we may see it surviving among the American Indians."³³

Finally, non-Jewish American writers, even ones with no particular affection for the Jews, thought that Indians would inevitably disappear but generally speaking did not think the same for the Jews. In most cases, available evidence was tied to emerging theories about genetics. Mendel's discovery of genetic laws of heredity inspired the search for various "unit characters" attached to various peoples, units that might include, in the case of Jews, "nomadism, habitual wandering, and 'thalasophilia' [leaving home for sea]."³⁴ Edward East's *Heredity and Human Affairs* claimed that the longevity of the Jews and their perpetual interbreeding insulated them from the tides of changing historical circumstance because and only because Jews engaged in stringently selective breeding. "The degenerate product of a bad genetic combination," on the other hand, wrote East, "is not saved by the record made by others of his race." "Historically the Jews are great," he argued. "[T]hey have wandered over the earth and have mingled their blood with the blood of other peoples . . . starting as a mixed race, they have become more mixed."³⁵ On the other hand, "the American Indian as a group have little of genetic value to contribute to the higher white or yellow subraces"; their interbreeding led only to degeneration. "One may assume," he concluded, "that the Indian will gradually disappear. He will be absorbed by the dominant white, without affecting the white race materially."³⁶

So one essential claim in American racial schemata was the notion that history would leave Indians behind; they were the disappearing, the disappeared. While Jews appeared as the focal point of so many awkward assessments

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a good thing?

of modernity's impact on America, Indians stood—with ever decreasing visibility—on the margins of consciousness as a kind of object lesson for those wishing to fully refuse modernity. As Goldstein, again, has shown, by the late nineteenth century, Americans expressed misgivings about modernity and the challenges it afforded to American identity. Ideas about racial outsiders—Jews, Indians, or others—reflected both broader reservations about the deleterious effects that modernization had on American life and the confident and forward-looking prowess of the wealth, growth, and power that Americans expected America would soon achieve.³⁷ It is perhaps not surprising then that the key associations that dominated American racial thinking about the Jews all found counterparts in Indians. The “Jewish qualities” of nervousness, intellectuality, and lack of physical developments were mirrored by “Indian qualities” of calm, corporeal competence, physical prowess, and connection to nature. These qualities were not just opposed to one another; they were characterizations of modernity itself and the kinds of human beings that modernity, and particularly urban American modernity, created.

DENYING THE PIONEER JEW

Perhaps the most popular motif in early twentieth-century discussions by non-Jewish writers that linked Jews and Native Americans centered on the retrospective accounting of late nineteenth-century pioneering and the extent to which “immigrants” could or should be excluded from the category “pioneer.” By the 1910s, just a handful of years after Frederick Jackson Turner famously declared the frontier “closed,” a new conceptual cleavage had opened up that distinguished between the European immigrant and American-born settler “pioneers” of the West and the post-1880 immigrants and Americans who arrived in that same West after the so-called closing. Looking back retrospectively from the early twentieth century, at a moment of enormous growth in new immigrant populations, many American commentators and scholars delineated what they argued to be a fundamental distinction between the older “pioneers/colonists” and the newer “immigrants.” Concerned about competition for jobs; the fast pace of urbanization, industrial growth, and factory conditions in American cities; and the seismic shifts in economic production, a slew of authors published best-selling works, written in panicked diction, about the immigrant “invasion.”

In his 1907 book, *Races and Immigrants in America*, University of Wisconsin scholar John Commons argued that Americanization happened in “the earlier days, [when] the most powerful agency of assimilation was frontier life [where pioneers] developed a spirit of self-reliance, a capacity for self-government, which are the most prominent characteristics of the American people.”³⁸ Jews, according to Commons, lacked this sort of industry and thrift. They had no time to be forged into Americans, for they “passed over” the critical pioneer stage,

arriving straight from Europe to the “parasitic motives . . . conditions of poverty and pauperism in the metropolis.”³⁹ Commons emphasized that pioneers’ actions and virtues, by contrast, were at root racial and that their dispossession of Native Americans took place because it conformed to a simple if brute truth about racial superiority. “The long series of crimes against the Indians,” he wrote, “must be looked upon as the mob spirit of a superior race bent on despoiling a despised and inferior race.”⁴⁰ The grounds for justifying dispossession, argued Commons, was that “the Indian has not accepted the white man’s standard of civilisation [sic] [. . . but] has remained true to his primitive tastes. In spite of a fair degree of opportunity to obtain training in the arts and sciences, an opportunity accepted by several thousand individuals, he has produced no man of real note. . . . One may assume, I believe, that the Indian will gradually disappear. He will be absorbed by the dominant white, without affecting the white race materially.”⁴¹ For Commons, as for many of those scholars who commented on race and immigration, Jews did not and could not participate in the pioneering process. *Races and Immigrants in America* offered the notion that “the Jewish immigrant, particularly, is unfitted for the life of a pioneer. Remarkably individualistic in character, his field of enterprise is society, and not the land.”⁴² For Commons, Jews seemed to be too civilized and too modern; they could not have modernized or civilized the frontier. Since Native Americans, on the other hand of this logic, could not be civilized, they would not participate in modernity. Arguing against more orthodox race thinkers, Commons claimed that even if the white race “absorbed” Indians, Indian race blood would not affect the white race “materially.” Commons’ critique of new immigrants typically featured American Indians as those who disappeared, defeated. Their defeat produced pioneers; *pioneers became Americans* by defeating Indian enemies. Once defeated, Indians were assumed to disappear altogether. Immigrants, in this circular logic, could therefore become neither pioneers nor Americans since they lacked Indians to defeat.

Similar sentiments were echoed the following year in Prescott Farnsworth Hall’s best-selling book, *Immigration and Its Effects upon the United States*, which repeated the distinction between “colonist” and “immigrant,” the former having battled Indians, while the latter had not. “In popular discussions of the immigration question it is often said that all who have come to this continent since its discovery should be considered equally as immigrants, and that only the aboriginal inhabitants can be properly called natives,” wrote Hall. This logic, however, he found “entirely misleading; for one cannot speak of immigration to a country until that country has entered upon a career of national existence. . . . Those who took part in building the political framework of the thirteen colonies” were colonists proper, different from “those who have arrived to find the United States Government and its social and political institutions in working operation. The former class have [sic] been called colonists, the latter are immigrants proper. In

discussing the immigration question, this distinction is important; for it does not follow that because, as against the native Indians, all comers might be considered as intruders and equally without claim of right.”⁴³

Hall distinguished “between the migration of tribes by means of conquest, and peaceful emigration which is the movement of individual units.” Peaceful emigrants were, essentially, the already conquered, as exemplified by the “Huguenots banished from France, the Jews driven from Spain, and, later, from Russia by the May Laws, and the Italians from the slums of Naples, [all] are instances of individuals conquered at home.”⁴⁴ His book mentioned Jews more than fifty times, generally distinguishing Jews from those “Pilgrims and Puritans [who sought] liberty and a chance to develop a new and lofty type of civil and religious commonwealth produced a civilization which, in spite of obvious defects, has excited the admiration of mankind.” These original colonists were to be contrasted with recent immigrants, who were “not led by the hope of bursting its bonds, but by the allurements of promised wealth and material comfort”: “The Jews we have received hitherto have . . . a keen personal ambition, and such law-breaking as they do is usually in the breach of sanitary regulations or in trying to gain some monetary advantage by craft and deceit. Although the history of many of these immigrants in Europe is something for which they are not responsible, it does not augur well for their future as American citizens. . . . The physical degeneration of the Jew in New York and Philadelphia has been accompanied to some extent by a moral and political degeneration.”⁴⁵ Hall’s chapter on “The Importance of Race Stock” argued that Jews constituted a menacing danger to American institutions and organic life, more far-reaching and potent than other threats. “The government, the state, society, industry, the political party, social and political ideals—all are concepts and conventions created by individual men; and when individuals change these change with them,” he wrote.⁴⁶

For Hall, religion was just as central as race: “Difference in religious belief may be one of the chief causes of heterogeneity, and one of the greatest of hindrances to assimilation. Members of the same religious sect, especially if surrounded by others of a different faith, tend to become clannish and separatist, and to affiliate only with newcomers of like faith, or, as sometimes is the case in New York City and elsewhere, with those of like faith and the same race. Difference in religion is a powerful bar to intermarriage, as in the case of the Jews.”⁴⁷ Hall’s constant juxtaposition of pilgrims versus new immigrants also reflected his conviction that Jews’ (and others’) lack of practice with democracy rendered them dangerous for the American project: “The early colonists of this country . . . were on the whole reverent of law and disposed to uphold the authorities constituted by the people. The later immigration was mostly from States and races long familiar with representative government. With the more recent immigration the case is quite otherwise. The more ignorant Italians, the Slavic races, the Syrians and other Asiatics, the Russian Hebrews,—all have come from lands where democracy is

unknown, and where law is represented to the people by soldiers, tax collectors, and gendarmerie.”⁴⁸ Jews’ lack of exposure to democracy, Hall believed, weakened their suitability for immigration.⁴⁹

The Jews’ potential to corrupt the ballot box, undermine democratic practice through law bending and subterfuge, or become a draining force on urban economies as wards of the state were not the only reasons that Jews could not be seen in and among those idealized frontier colonial types according to nativist thinkers of the early twentieth century. Frank Julian Warne’s 1913 book, *The Immigrant Invasion*, added concern about Jews as threats to the displacement of already American workers, the rising of consumer goods prices, and the driving down of wages, the building of shanty living arrangements, the rise of disability, and the decrease of patriotism. Warne, a journalist and economist who had served as the secretary of the immigration department of the National Civic Federation of New York, the New York State Immigration Commission, and the U.S. Census Bureau, even suggested that new immigrants were to blame in the persistence of “the negro problem,” since, he reasoned, new immigrants were replacing the low-paying service jobs that Blacks often had, increasing Black poverty and disenfranchisement. Constantly deploying words like “threat,” “invasion,” “foreign,” and “impact,” Warne celebrated “the Older immigration” as hearty, muscular, rugged, homesteading, Indian clearing pioneers, industrious, and those who were able to invent a vision of democracy.⁵⁰ The common task of American-born and new immigrants from the 1810s to 1840s had been one that seamlessly blended the economic, racial, political, and social to provide a national boon in defeating and removing Indians. Post-1860s immigrants, by contrast, lived in cities and were overly preoccupied with competition. Claimed Warne,

The remarkable story of this westward march prior to the eighties of our older foreign-born population, and its consequences to us as a nation, . . . the interior West was taken from the Indian, cleared of its forests, and only now is being subjected to supplying the wants and needs of modern civilization. There the native American and the European immigrant had a common task, and they became neighbors and friends, intermarriage was made easy, and the Teutonic and Celtic races, which in Europe had for centuries been developing separate and apart, were welded or fused racially as one people. Not only was the environment such as to amalgamate them physically but also to assimilate them politically and socially.⁵¹

The “old newcomers” were colonists; the crucible of the old West fused the English, Irish, Welsh, Scotch, Norwegian, Dane, Swede, Swiss, Hollander, and Canadian, a “great movement of population out of Europe . . . toward the setting sun . . . [whose] longings and struggles of the race of mankind in their peopling of the New World with a new race, and in their travail to give birth and perpetuate a government of, by and for the people . . . those anxious and stirring days

when the path of the pioneer crossed the path of the Indian, and the axe and the plough of the white settler replaced the tomahawk and bow of the red man. . . . For they too concern themselves with fundamental human forces out of which alone a new epoch grows." New newcomers—the Jews chief among them—were merely immigrants.

For nativists, then, Jews were excluded from identification in the frontier "type." The fact that so many commentators and scholars who discussed Jews, Indians, and the nature of the frontier experience failed to recognize that there were many actual encounters between Jews and Native Americans—that Jews were indeed colonial settlers on the frontier (described at length in the first half of this book)—further served to smear immigrants by disqualifying them from participation in the model, exalted citizen of America's national imagination. The setup of implied oppositions—those between frontiersmen and Indians and between frontiersmen and Jews—also says something about perceptions of both Indians and Jews—namely, that Jews and Indians were in relation with one another as mutual, twinned foils to colonist pioneers, albeit on opposing ends of exclusion. Both forms of differentiation echo the 1924 Acts, twin gestures of white primacy.

1924: INTERWEAVING NATIVIST ACTS OF CONGRESS

Jewish and Native American experiences overlapped, intersected, and contradicted one another in discussions about the nature of American national identity by non-Jews and non-Indians about who truly belonged in the American people, who threatened it, and about just how Christian America was or ought to have been. These overlaps, intersections, and contradictions played out in both academic discussions and policy venues. They came to a head in 1924, as two congressional acts of thematically interrelated legislation emerged, each of them aiming to shape the American character by crafting boundaries about who belonged and who did not.

Congress passed the Immigration Act, also known as the Johnson-Reed Act, in May 1924. The Immigration Act included the National Origins Act, which effectively halted southern and eastern European immigration, including Jewish immigration, to the United States. The act also included the Asia Exclusion Act, which entirely banned Asian immigration. In the congressional record, restrictionists explicitly denounced theories of Nordic superiority. Nevertheless, the quota system enacted in the act itself drew from deep-rooted assumptions about the racial, moral, physical, and intellectual qualities of potential immigrants. The National Origins Act spoke to a widely shared nativist xenophobia that President Coolidge, in his inaugural address, captured when he supported immigration restriction, declaring that "America must be kept American. For this purpose it is necessary to continue a policy of restricted immigration."⁵²

Just one month later, Congress passed the Indian Citizenship Act, following an earlier act of 1919, which had given citizenship to those Indians who had

served in armed forces during the Great War. The Indian Citizenship Act granted citizenship to those remaining Native American men who had not been previously naturalized by treaty, though full suffrage was not completed for many, and several states refused to recognize Indians as citizens altogether. The Indian Citizenship Act is widely understood by historians and Native intellectuals to have been an effort to erase Indian difference through assimilation, a symbolic act of inclusion that in fact stripped Indians of legal room to fight for political sovereignty.⁵³

These two acts of legislation reveal an America preoccupied with threats about membership and anxieties about identity and difference.⁵⁴ Both acts served one end—namely, to further root American identity in its Anglo-cultural, religiously Christian, and racially white heritage. One aimed to repel the threat of foreign contamination by immigrants from without, while the other aimed to dissolve the alien within by absorption.

Of course, major differences separated the two discussions. The fraught debate about immigration restriction occupied a central place in American social, legal, historical, and even scientific discussion and had been percolating from the 1880s, if not earlier. On the other hand, the debate about Indian citizenship preoccupied only a small public.⁵⁵ The discussion grew out of civil servants' efforts to assimilate American Indians, drawing from a long tradition entangled in missionary activity and piecemeal actions and protocols by local, state, and BIA initiatives. (These efforts were supported, in part, by some Native American leaders and by the Indian Rights Association, an influential group of policy activists whose express goal was to "bring about the complete civilization of the Indians and their admission to citizenship."⁵⁶) The federal government had sponsored compulsory assimilation programs for Native Americans as a matter of national policy going back to Ulysses Grant's "Peace Policy" of the 1870s and the Dawes Act of 1887 (and its amendments in 1891 and 1906), which offered Native peoples land allotments and promoted individual ownership and freed up millions of acres of land for further settlement. Assimilationist policies continued through the turn of the century with residential boarding schools, several key legal decisions, and the suppression of certain Native religious practices until the Indian New Deal under John Collier at the BIA and the Roosevelt Administration.

The assimilation campaign that Jews faced, on the other hand, was ad hoc; it was subtler and relatively more benign than the one faced by Native Americans. Most importantly, the campaign that targeted Jews for assimilation was only in the realm of culture; it was not waged against Jews through legislative or judicial mechanisms. Though American Jews felt pressures to adjust or transform their bodies, speech patterns, styles of dress, tastes in food, and the ways they practiced religious rites or prayer, chose occupations, or even shaped their unwritten values, these pressures were never mounted as official state or federal policy. This

point is worth emphasizing: whereas the state sponsored assimilationist policies directed at Native Americans, it pursued no such campaigns aimed at Jews.

Yet despite the clear differences, civil servants and lawmakers entangled Jews and Indians in the debates on the bills that lead up to the passage of the 1924 Acts and in the acts themselves. The chairman of the House Immigration Committee, Albert Johnson, read from consular cables provided by the State Department during one of Congress's debates on an immigration restriction bill, attesting to Jews as "subnormal," "twisted," "deteriorated," and "full of perverted ideas," who—in contrast to the normal, straight, invigorated immigrant pioneers—"are not those [immigrants] who hewed the forests, . . . conquered the wastes, and built America. These are beaten folk."⁵⁷ Jews' apparent inability to conquer Indians rendered them unappealing candidates for naturalization.

Even the language of these two acts tangled immigrants and Indians together. The Indian Citizenship Act alluded to immigrants, and the National Origins Act referred to Native Americans. The one-sentence-long Indian Citizenship Act specified that it proclaimed citizens of "all non citizen Indians *born within the territorial limits of the United States*"—that is, Indians who did not migrate to U.S. territory after birth.⁵⁸ The language of the act went out of its way to define Indians as nonimmigrants. And for its part, the National Origins Act, despite its express focus on immigrants, went out of its way to reference Native Americans in order to define its most basic terms; it used Indians as the foil through which to define nonnaturalized non-Americans. In its language, immigrants were "aliens," a term the act clarified as including "any individual not a native-born or naturalized citizen of the U.S.," adding, critically, express terms to exclude Indians (and the populations of America's colonial holdings) from the category of *alien*. The act stated, "This definition [of aliens] shall not be held to include Indians of the U.S. not taxed, nor citizens of the islands under the jurisdiction of the U.S."⁵⁹ Both of these 1924 race-based laws struggled with awkward caveats, granting and withholding, in order to exclude racialized minorities.

These two acts also evoked (or re-evoked) long-standing fears shared by Jews and Indians alike. The acts inflamed Jewish and Indian responses to predictions about the inevitable disappearance both of Jews as such and of Indians as such. American Jews and Native Americans both fretted over their felt exclusion from the mainstream American body politic, and both feared that their corporate identities might be lost. Jews and Native Americans both articulated and worked through these parallel anxieties. Both mobilized, both organized, and both publicized counter-polemics.⁶⁰ The enactments of these two policies make evident the consequences of racial discourse on mass populations of both Indians and immigrants in the United States.

RHETORICAL USES OF IMMIGRANT VS. INDIAN

Jewish journalists, politicians, scholars, and writers countered nativist racist, anti-Jewish, and anti-immigrant sentiment. In a wide host of forums and settings, Jews offered several complementary arguments. While some argued that the Jewish race or people had made adequate contributions to American life, others insisted that there was no such thing as race. Still other Jewish commentators asserted that restrictionist policies were logically inconsistent or incompatible with fundamental values of America or its constitution; they mounted legal challenges. American Jews also proffered moral suasion based on their history or suffering and their brethren's contemporary afflictions in Europe and Russia. Immigration constituted a prime object of concern for practically every major Jewish defense and community-relations organization. American Jews helped establish and finance nonsectarian groups like the National Liberal Immigration League and the Citizens Committee for Displaced Persons. They were perhaps "the single most persistent pressure group favoring a liberal immigration policy in the United States in the entire immigration debate beginning in 1881," as historian Kevin MacDonald has argued.⁶¹ In undertaking to sway immigration policy in a liberal direction, Jewish spokesmen and organizations demonstrated a degree of energy "unsurpassed by any other interested pressure group."⁶²

Jews were among many religious, business, and legal voices that protested nativist currents and the bills that eventually became the National Origins Act.⁶³ Young urban Jews argued against restriction on the floor of Congress. Only two of the seventeen members of Congress's committee voted against the lead bill, both of whom were Jews: Adolph Sabath and Samuel Dickstein, who notably later chaired the House of Representatives Subcommittee on Indian Affairs in the late 1930s. Meyer Jacobstein, Nathan Perlman, and Emanuel Celler (who, notably, later introduced both the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965, which abolished the quota system based on national origins in place since the 1920s, and the Indian Civil Rights Act of 1968) all challenged the race-implied assumptions in the proposal. They argued against the explicit racism of the anti-immigrant lobby, spearheaded by Madison Grant, the previously discussed life-long eugenics campaigner. Grant belonged to, founded, or sat on the executive board of some thirty-five different organizations that represented a wide net of American race preservation fights for white supremacy, including the American Eugenics Society, the Eugenics Research Association, the International Congress of Eugenics, and the Galton Society.⁶⁴ Grant also served as the chair of Congress' Committee on Selective Immigration. His book, *The Passing of the Great Race*, served as one of the core texts in the immigration restriction debate. Grant and his fellow nativists—what historian Jonathan Spiro has called an "interlocking directorate" of eugenicists and anti-immigration activists—flooded journals and newspapers in support of the 2 percent 1890 immigrant ratio quota that was

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suggested and eventually adopted in the 1924 Act, arguing that such restriction would save America from parasitical races. This formula allowed for the entry of 2 percent of the total number of immigrants by homeland of origin that were admitted in the year 1890. The *Saturday Evening Post*, *American Magazine*, the *North American Review*, and even the *New York Times* used words like *poison*, *infection*, and *parasite* in reference to immigration and showed an obsession with digestion metaphors.⁶⁵

In concert with these metaphors of disease and indigestion, non-Jewish, non-Indian writers served up a steady stream of commentary that stressed that both groups would inevitably disappear. Anxiety about group erasure frequently gnawed at the periphery of American Jewish consciousness and found articulation among a diverse group of Jewish journalists, novelists, rabbis, and scholars.⁶⁶

As a general response to nativist anti-immigrant sentiment, Jews themselves wrote of a sense of kinship and identification with American Indians. On occasion, Jewish writers supported Indian land claims against federal governments at home (and abroad) with the explicit recognition that having a land of one's own would preserve Indian tribes and keep them from the dustbin of history. One journalist writing in the *Jewish Criterion* evoked the Hebrew Bible (Leviticus 23) in support of the "Mexican Indians" and their rising up to possess land.⁶⁷

Jewish intellectuals had long feared Jewish corporate disappearance and had a history of using Indians in their rhetorical appeals when they gave voice to it. In his 1899 *History of Yiddish Literature in the Nineteenth Century*, Leo Wiener wrote of his concern for the loss of Jewish literature, language, and cultural forms, all of which he believed were threatened by the assimilative forces of an America unconcerned with cloistering Jews in a separate sphere.⁶⁸ Wiener, a Russian-born Polish Jew, historian, linguist, translator of Tolstoy, and professor of Slavic languages at Harvard University, bemoaned the assimilatory prospects of Jews in America, suggesting that the literatures and languages of "the Gypsies, the Malay, and the American Indian" had greater chances for linguistic survival given their continued seclusion. Wiener's fear of the disappearance of Yiddish bespoke a greater fear that many Jews shared about their cultural and biological disappearance altogether. Scholars and writers worried that linguistic assimilation could lead to more insidious forms of assimilation.⁶⁹

In a radio talk during his much-feted tour of the United States to study American Indians, the German Jewish art historian Aby Warburg feared aloud that the Jews' fate in America might follow that of the Indian, that the pressures on American peoples to assimilate lead to the homogenization of cultures and "mental habits." One Jewish newspaper concurred with Warburg's expressed fears of "the standardization of minds and emotions of Red Indians."⁷⁰ Warburg fretted that the loss of this more soulful aspect of group cultural life would have even more deleterious effects on Jewish life—as it had on Indian life—than even the loss of traditional linguistic vernacular, the impact of materialism, or the loss of Jewish folkways. The consequences of artistic "standardization," a proxy for a

culture's very soul, Warburg worried, could be catastrophic. The standardization of mind, and "not the adoption by American Jews of the English language for the use in their daily intercourse and in the home, or the material comforts of America, or certain traditional folkways of the land [is what] makes Mr. Warburg fearful for the future of Jewry in this country."⁷¹

Of particular interest are the ways that Jewish antirestrictionist agents regularly used tropes of "the Indian" in their proimmigration polemics. While they promoted Jewish immigration and integration with consistent appeals to Indians, the nature of this rhetorical Indian with whom Jews alternatively allied themselves or contrasted themselves with changed dramatically, depending on the utility of a given argument. The figure of the Indian proved malleable and flexible in the hands of Jewish rhetoricians. The Hebrew Immigrant Aid Society, dedicated to encouraging the free flow of Jews from eastern Europe into a safe America willing to absorb them, used its newspaper arm, the *Jewish Immigrant*, for example, as a platform on "the immigration question" by constructing various rhetorical Indians in its arguments. It published New York congressman William Sulzer's proimmigration, proassimilation polemic, an "eloquent plea for justice to the immigrants," in which he argued that Jews belonged in America because as white immigrants, they wished to blend into America's white body and could labor on the otherwise useless "millions and millions of acres of rich, fertile land waiting to be cultivated."⁷² His counterarguments to anti-immigration proponents rested on the expansionist idea that America needed quality laborers who might easily adapt to American social norms and make the vast tracts of lands productive. As if empty of persons and empty of productive utility, Indian lands lay "waiting to be cultivated," since, he implied, government efforts to make Indians into productive agricultural laborers had amounted to little. Immigrants' adaptability, in counter-distinction, rested in their racial characteristics and their closeness to other white Americans, Hungarians, Italians, and Germans. For Sulzer, the value of immigrants' labor capacities and racial flexibility trumped even the idea, as he reasoned it, that being white did not, ipso facto, make one into a "real" part of the nation. "Many of the people opposed to immigration," he insisted, "never stop to consider that none of us are real Americans—Americans in the fullest sense of the word. THE INDIAN IS THE ONLY REAL AMERICAN."⁷³

The trope of Indians as the immigrant's opposite recurred again and again in Jewish public discourse in the early decades of the twentieth century and was linked to themes of productivity, disease, capacity for assimilation, contribution to civilization, prospects for leadership, and the generation of local or national wealth. Jews regularly located the essence of citizenship and national belonging in productivity and in harnessing the land and its resources for prosperity. To the extent that Jews assumed that Indians failed to structure their communal lives with this goal in mind, they also excluded Indians from the nation itself. This discourse did not consider Native Americans in their own right, but only as a mute foil. One prong of proimmigration rhetoric sought to decenter the

idea of American natural authenticity by linking it with Indians—if the only “natural” Americans were Native Americans, no immigrant could be considered an authentic American. Though this rhetorical strategy devalued the actual places and circumstances of Native Americans in American life and implied that Native Americans lacked the capacity to be productive, civic, or just American, the implication was easily expendable. Few advocates for American Indians ever weighed in to discussions about immigration and naturalization; advocacy work for Indians in health, education, or any other sector simply was not on the radar in way that it was for Blacks or poor whites.

Jews mobilized the idea of Indian aboriginality against the forces that aimed to exclude eastern and southern European immigrant groups. Pittsburgh’s *Jewish Criterion* steadily ran editorials and articles from the 1910s through the 1940s espousing this view. Its editor, Charles H. Joseph, argued for the rights of immigrant citizens as co-equals to American-born whites, writing that immigrants adopted America just as America adopted its immigrants “in the same way that all other people of the earth have adopted it.”⁷⁴ Only Indians stood outside this principle of adoption. “The Indians alone are the real Americans,” he wrote. “All the remainder of the population consists of foreigners. But under our Constitution when a foreigner becomes naturalized and secures his citizen papers, he has the same rights, without respect to his religious beliefs, as the gentlemen who ran over in the Mayflower.”⁷⁵ In Joseph’s proimmigration rhetoric, all foreigners, even the founding fathers, had to become “real Americans” like the Indians through naturalizing.

The rhetoric was manifestly confused. Indians were the only real Americans; they made Americans but somehow could never be real Americans. The essence of American identity, so ran the argument, was focused instead on rights and citizens’ abilities or capacities to act them out. Joseph’s newspaper ran editorials over the next three decades to similar effects, shifting rhetorical uses of Indians. “It is singular,” wrote one of its editorialists, “nay it is unpardonable, to hear the chauvinistic cry, to see the intolerant wave of anti-foreign sentiments emanate from people themselves of foreign parentage, of a nationality which is a composite of many foreign nationalities, transferred to these shores, earlier or later, and here mixed and modified in the American crucible. . . . The only ‘original’ Americans are the aboriginal tribes of Indians, fast perishing and never suggested to the thought of the civilized world by that name, but rather by the name of ‘the Red man of North America.’”⁷⁶

Jewish proimmigration rhetoric utilized the idea of the Indian in competing, complementary, and even contradictory ways. In some polemics, Jews could be counted as nationals among a nation of non-Indians. Simply being an immigrant or having descended from one offered sufficient reason for a people’s welcome in America. In other polemics, however, all forms of intolerance were deemed inimical to American values. Racism aiming to exclude Jews, other immigrant groups, or Indians was said to sting with equal perniciousness. An editorial

by Rabbi Beryl D. Cohon argued “that there is no such thing as an American by race. Americanism cannot be based on race, for the American is a combination of every race of Europe.”⁷⁷ He claimed that “the American holds within his veins the blood of the American Indians, plus the blood of the Negroes, and plus the blood of some Asiatic folk,” mixing natives and newcomers into an amalgamated ideal citizen.⁷⁸ Welcoming immigrants and loving America’s Indian and Negro “blood” went hand in hand. Any form of exclusionary racism, the rabbi suggested, offended Americans as a nation without race. In this argument, American nationality trumped racial distinctions between minorities in America.

Some Jewish proimmigration rhetoric made use of the idea that only Indians enjoyed the status of nonimmigrants in America. Other strategies aimed to undermine both anti-immigrant and anti-Indian sentiment. In both rhetorics of advocacy, Jews sought to undermine racist sentiment while preserving ethnic corporate solidarity. But not every strategy Jews took to keep America’s doors open to future Jewish immigration explicitly criticized racialist thinking. On occasion, Jewish voices for liberal immigration policy deployed racist sentiment too, though they pointed it at non-Jews. Joshua Kantrowitz of the B’nai B’rith and Judge B. A. Rosenblatt of the American Jewish Congress argued for the restriction of Asians but entitlements for Jews. William Edlin, the editor of *Der Yiddishe Tog*, likewise suggested that Jews, on account of their relative racial closeness to the founding races of America, should be accepted, while the exclusions should only apply to nonwhites. “I am speaking here on behalf of the Caucasian race,” he wrote, “to which we all belong. I do not want to take in those races which [sic] do not assimilate readily. . . . After all . . . the Chinese, Hindus and other races do not have those things that we call civilization, and I look upon those people as too far from us for assimilation purposes.”⁷⁹ Jewish proimmigrant rhetoric was far from consistent in anything other than its ultimate objective.

Such proimmigration and assimilation polemics by Jewish writers certainly faced rebuttals by non-Jewish nativists. The most successful and dominant metaphor for racial integration in America was by far the idea of the “melting pot,” a term that was catapulted into the American public imagination after the Washington debut of a play of the same name by British Jewish author Israel Zangwill in 1909 (at which President Teddy Roosevelt was in attendance). The play told a story about a Russian Jewish immigrant and his effort to wed a Christian woman. Victorious in the end, the play celebrated America as “the great melting pot where all the races of Europe are melting and re-forming!”⁸⁰ As a phrase that would come to capture the Turnerian idea of race amalgamation in the West and expanded it to a broader American public, including later periods of immigration, restrictionist writers took aim at the “melting pot” trope.

Henry Pratt Fairchild’s 1926 best-selling book, *The Melting Pot Mistake*, for instance, aimed to account for the ultimate effects upon the “vitality and solidarity of this stupendous injection of foreign elements” and argued that the

melting pot was a false ideal because racial outsiders could not assimilate.⁸¹ True citizens, the book argued (even after the restrictionist victory of the National Origins Act of 1924), could not be made out of aliens, but the efforts to try to square a round peg by allowing unchecked immigration necessarily impacted “the vigor and permanence of our life as a nation.”⁸² The metaphor of the melting pot, wrote Fairchild, was invented “to convince the American that immigration did not threaten its unity, but tended to produce an even finer type of unity. It failed because it did not take into account the true nature of group unity, of the conditions of its preservation, or of the actual consequences of such in-roads upon unity as are involved in an immigration movement.”⁸³ Concerned with race mixing and degeneration, Fairchild marshaled racist arguments from biology and evolution and concluded that “*the primary basis of group unity is therefore racial*,” and suggested that “one of the chief courses of fallacy in the figure of the melting pot lay in the failure to make this crucial distinction . . . race traits are due solely to inheritance,” which he considered transmitted hereditarily and fixed from birth to death.⁸⁴ The traits of nationality, he argued, on the other hand, were distinctly group or social realities (rather than biological ones) since they “impress themselves on the individual but by no means ineradicably. Race is inherited, nationality is acquired.”⁸⁵

Fairchild considered new immigration “a New Menace.” Of “the great bulk of Hebrew immigration in recent years,” he wrote, “the immigration problem in the US has become increasingly a racial problem in two distinct ways, first by altering profoundly the Nordic predominance in the American population, and second by introducing new elements which, while of uncertain volume, are so radically different from any of the old ingredients that even small quantities are deeply significant.”⁸⁶ Fairchild argued that there could be no “give-and-take” in assimilation, that race mixing could only have deleterious effects, and that immigrants must lose all traces of foreign origin, including language, religion, political ideas, moral standards, economic abilities, dress, recreation, food, ornamentation, family customs, habits, traditions, beliefs and loyalties.⁸⁷ “In all of these particulars,” he advised, “the immigrant must be transformed into the type of the receiving nationality.”⁸⁸

Fairchild also tried to rebut those of his opponents who lumped together all non-Native Americans as fellow immigrants in their championing of immigration and assimilation. “Speakers who pose as champions of a ‘liberal’ policy may frequently be heard to declare, The only true Americans are the Red Indians. All the rest of us are immigrants, or the descendants of immigrants,” he wrote. Following this logic, he argued, one would have to conclude that the only thing that “constitutes an American is ancient residence upon a certain territory, which was not even called America until after the white men discovered it.” But Fairchild insisted that Indians had no “better claim to the honored title [of native] than the later arrivals, for they themselves are the descendants of wanderers who came from somewhere else,” that they were, in effect, immigrants too.⁸⁹

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He took specific umbrage with leaders of the “Hebrew population” who wished to preserve and maintain Jewish cultural and religious heritage as the “dangerous . . . type of foreigner who lacks the will to assimilate includ[ing] those who, on high intellectual and cultural grounds, oppose assimilation because of the in-roads it makes into the strength of their own original nationalities”; he criticized the “considerable propaganda in existence in the US at this present time designed to encourage immigrants to oppose and resist assimilation . . . [by] Rabbis and other prominent Jewish leaders.” He pointed out that these exact sentiments were admirable “when displayed by Americans in foreign lands” as proud patriotism. Such persons, however, “constitute an undeniable menace to American national stability,” since the antiassimilation impulse leads to a kind of split loyalty. “The wholesome place for the display of patriotism is at home,” under normal circumstances, he wrote. However, “the difficulty in the case of the Jews is that they have no home. They have no nation to the upbuilding of which they can devote their restless activities, and about the future of which they can entwine their ardent aspirations. . . . This is wholly defensible from the point of view of the Jews. It is intolerable from the point of view of other nationalities.”⁹⁰

The puzzle of identifying the nature of Jewish difference and then evaluating the possibility of Jewish belonging was made into a matter of race science,



Figure 4.1. “History of the USA.” The comic strip presents a narrative western U.S. history in which the American pioneer and patriot removed the Indian from the land, only to be ousted by the Jewish immigrant. Courtesy of National Museum of American Jewish History, Philadelphia, Peter H. Schweitzer Collection of Jewish Americana, print 2006.1.6258

geography, connections to an ancient past, character, biology, and heredity. It was also made, finally, a matter of religion since Anglo-Saxon supremacist thinking shared a common link with Protestants who considered America as a fulfillment of a Christian vision of society and modernity. The Jews' difference from Christians in respect to religion and Indian difference varied greatly. Avowedly Christian writers also took an active interest in immigration debates, offering both pro- and anti-immigration perspectives. In their 1913 study, *The New America: A Study in Immigration*, for example, Mary Clark Barnes and Lemuel Barnes advocated for keeping the immigration doors open to Jews with arguments drawn from religious grounds.⁹¹ The book was issued under the direction of the Council of Women for Home Missions, as part of its Interdenominational Home Mission Study Course set of books, which also included titles like *Under Our Flag*, *God's Melting Pot*, *Comrades from Other Lands*, and *Some Immigrant Neighbors*. The book aimed to Christianize "the strangers within our gates" and promoted immigration among the illiterate for cheap labor, the growth of national wealth, and the expansion of Christianity. Christianity provided a route to economic success. The authors advocated for Jewish immigration on the grounds that Jews would fare well and that they were important targets of conversion efforts. The racial characterization of Jews in works like these served to affirm a preexisting religious conviction that America offered a space for the flourishing and future of Christianity. Jews' supposed tenacity in life and their innate "tenacity of purpose" rendered them ideal immigrants and objects for missionizing.⁹²

Does this mean that some viewed Jews as an ideal target to entice to assimilate?

High rates of literacy, the eagerness of children to learn, and the ability to blend civics and religion were all virtues that Jews supposedly helped import to North America. Even the Jews' idea of God was an import. "And, behold, the glory of the God of Israel came from the way of the East," they quoted from scripture, as a proof text for the notion of God as a force for amalgamation and Christian consolidation in America.⁹³ "It must not be forgotten that the fundamental literature of America is not American, nor African, nor even European, but Asiatic. . . . 'The father of the faithful' was a wandering Asiatic sheik. The God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob is our God. . . . Most of all, the supreme center of the divine revelation to us is in One who was primarily not American, or European but Asiatic."⁹⁴

Are Jews being referred to as Asiatic here or an Indian/Asiatic?

TURNING TOWARD ACTIVISM

A wide manner of American writings about immigration, race, and nation made use of Indians to produce competing ideas about home and belonging, which sometimes included Jews and sometimes excluded them. Anti-Jewish and anti-Indian sentiments were all nourished from the same well. These twin forms of American exclusionism found multiple and competing expressions in a variety of settings and sites throughout the early decades of the twentieth century. They shaped the Immigration Act and the Indian Citizenship Act of 1924. These

strands of exclusionism were continuously braided in the writings of racial theorists, eugenicists, immigration commentators, and assessors of the recent American past who eagerly sought to define exalted citizens by focusing on peoples excluded from its making: Jews, Blacks and Indians.

Jews themselves intervened in these discussions; they responded with their own rhetorical uses of Indians. Fearing that white America's assimilatory aspiration for them would lead to their cultural obliteration, Jews looked to Indians as a bellwether, a cautionary tale, and a foil in situating themselves in recent American history. Their "Indians" were mostly imagined. Their supposed distance from mainstream newcomer, Christian, white Americans made Indians, in the social unconscious of early twentieth-century American Jews, convenient oppositional figures that Jews used to define their own relative closeness to the Americans they hoped would include and embrace them. Indian difference was both different and other; Jewish difference, Jews hoped, would merely be different. Yet in using Indians rhetorically in arguments promoting belonging and continued liberal immigration policy, Jews began schooling themselves in the language of a broader, more inclusive antirace rhetoric, which, as chapter 5 will show, they deployed in an intensely activist manner on behalf of Native Americans.

American Jewish responses to nativist xenophobia took recourse in American Indians; the idea of "Indians" provided Jews with a useful and malleable rhetorical tool for confronting tensions around themes that unsettled Jewish consciousness: assimilation and disappearance, naturalization, citizenship, the idea of adoption, and the nature and impact of Jewish religious difference. Jews took advantage of the flexibility that both "the Jew" and "the Indian" had in racial hierarchies in the first quarter of the twentieth century, as Americans became ever more preoccupied with race thinking and its implications for national policy. Though nativists consistently cast Jews in hierarchically superior standing to Indians, they often put Jews and Indians into relation with one another in their discussions of racial character types and their debates about who could be assimilated to the national ideal type. Over the same years, nativists cut Jews from the conceptual category of "pioneers" as part of a broader anti-immigration polemic and, in so doing, denied the complicated relationships that actual Jews had with actual Native Americans. Anti-Jewish and anti-Indian sentiments intertwined, coming to a head at the highest echelons of American life in 1924, with the passing of both the National Origins Act and the Indian Citizenship Act.